

This week's פרשיות are פרשת וילך, and include פרשת וילך, the shortest פרשה in the Torah. Nevertheless, it has a powerhouse full of wonderful things to learn, one of which is what we will do now from the וילנא גאון. In וילנא גאון, מדרש ילקוט, brought down in התורה על התורה, says that the day that משה רבינו was going to be נפטר, Hashem's שכינה moved over to Yehoshua and was speaking to Yehoshua. שאל לו משה - Moshe asked Yehoshua; מה אמר לך ה' - What did Hashem tell you? אמר לו יהושע, וכי כל ארבעים שנה שאלתי אותך מה דיבר ה' - Yehoshua's answer to Moshe was, "And in all the 40 years, did I ever ask you what Hashem said?" Immediately משה רבינו said, טוב אלף, פלא'דיגע מדרש - Better to die a thousand times than to have a moment of קנאה. A פלא'דיגע מדרש from beginning to the end.

The first question is, is this the way that Yehoshua could possibly speak to משה רבינו under any circumstances? That's the obvious question. We are amazed to hear such a statement. And the second question is, what in fact did הקדוש ברוך הוא tell Yehoshua that was so vital, so important?

The וילנא גאון answers in a way that only the וילנא גאון could. הקדוש ברוך הוא wanted משה רבינו to pass away very calmly, with נפש חפצה, willingly. We know that Moshe Rabbeinu davened 515 תפילות. One of his requests was that if indeed the time had come for Yehoshua to take over leadership - since אין מלכות אחת נוגעת בהברתה, two kings cannot rule at the same time - then let Yehoshua be the Rebbe and Moshe be the talmid. "At least", Moshe asked, "allow me to go into ארץ ישראל so I can perform the מצוות there. I don't want to die before I have this opportunity."

This will not be easy for him. In fact, he will not be able to tolerate it at all. Therefore, as usual, the two קשיות answer each other. What did Hashem tell Yehoshua? Hashem told him: when Moshe asks you "What did Hashem say to you?" you should respond, "And in all the forty years, did I ever ask you what Hashem said?" He was quoting Hashem's words exactly, word for word.

So for one split second, a millisecond, משה רבינו would think Yehoshua is saying such a thing, and he'll say to himself, I'd rather die than have קנאה. משה רבינו himself quickly realized that that's exactly what Hashem said to Yehoshua. But that one moment was enough to give him the קנאה to no longer want to go along with his הוה אמינא to be the talmid.

I did not know what those four letters were, so I asked a few people and ended up calling R' Hershel Schachter, who told me, and I wrote it in my sefer here, דפח"ה - דברי פי חכם הן - The words of a wise man are very pleasant, are very beautiful.

הקדוש ברוך ה' teaches us that everything is for our own good. וילנא גאון on the פרשה teaches us that everything is for our own good. וילנא גאון, פרקי אבות, says in פרקי אבות, we have to be מקבל it. As it says in פרקי אבות, we have to be מקבל it with שמחה. אם ירצה ה', we should have געבענטשט געזונט יאר, daven that Hashem should not send us נסיונות, and in fact give us אריכות ימים, opportunities to do more and more מצוות, and that we should be זוכה to see גואל צדק this year.

